

A 20-Year-Old Star Shines Bright in Scotland's First World Cup Win in 36 Years!

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Have you ever waited so long for something that it felt like forever? For Scotland's soccer fans, the wait was 36 years that's older than most of their players! On Saturday in Boston, Scotland finally won a men's World Cup match again, beating Haiti 1-0. But the real story wasn't the goal scorer. It was a 20-year-old **winger** named Ben Gannon-Doak who played with so much heart that fans couldn't stop talking about him. In the 54th minute, Gannon-Doak did something simple: he **shielded** the ball so it went out for a Scotland goal kick. But then he roared, punched the air, and celebrated like he'd just scored the winning goal! The crowd of Scottish fans, called the **Tartan Army**, went wild. They were nervous because the game was close, but Gannon-Doak's fire lifted everyone up. He wasn't even born the last time Scotland played in a World Cup that was way back in 1998. Two years ago, he was picked for the **European Championship** but got hurt and couldn't play. Then he had three big injuries, including a **hamstring** that was "hanging on by a thread." But now he's healthy and showed the world what he can do. John McGinn scored the only goal, but Gannon-Doak was the spark. He even helped set up a cool **bicycle kick** earlier in the game. After the match, he said he prays and reads the Bible before games to stay calm. Scotland's next match is against Denmark, and with Gannon-Doak on the field, fans are dreaming big.

Word Treasure

winger -- A winger is a soccer player who usually plays near the left or right side of the field.

shielded -- Shielding the ball means using your body to protect it from an opponent so they can't take it.

Tartan Army -- The Tartan Army is the nickname for Scotland's very loud and loyal soccer fans.

hamstring -- A hamstring is an important leg muscle that helps you run, and it can get torn if you're not careful.

European Championship -- The European Championship is a huge soccer tournament held every four years where European nations compete.

bicycle kick -- A bicycle kick is a flashy soccer move where a player jumps and kicks the ball while flying backward through the air.

Background you need

Haiti is a country on an island in the Caribbean Sea, and its soccer team rarely plays in the World Cup.

The last time Scotland's men's team played in a World Cup was in 1998, before many of today's players were born.

Ben Gannon-Doak is a young Scottish winger who fought through several serious injuries, including a hamstring that almost tore completely.

Break it down

WHO: Ben Gannon-Doak, a 20-year-old Scottish winger, and his teammate John McGinn who scored the goal.

WHAT: Scotland beat Haiti 1-0 in their first men's World Cup win in 36 years, sparked by Gannon-Doak's intense celebration after a small defensive play.

WHERE: The match happened in Boston.

WHY: Gannon-Doak's fierce energy and determination lifted the nervous team and fans, proving that moments of passion can change a game.

Why it matters

If you've ever had to keep trying after getting hurt, this story shows that courage and spirit can make you, and everyone around you, shine.

Test what you remember

1. Who scored the only goal for Scotland?

- ☐ (A) Ben Gannon-Doak
- ☐ (B) John McGinn
- ☐ (C) A Haitian player
- ☐ (D) The Tartan Army

2. How many years had Scotland waited to win a men's World Cup match?

- ☐ (A) 20 years
- ☐ (B) 36 years
- ☐ (C) 1998 years
- ☐ (D) 54 years

3. What did Ben Gannon-Doak do that made the Scottish fans go wild?

- ☐ (A) He scored a goal
- ☐ (B) He did a bicycle kick
- ☐ (C) He shielded the ball and celebrated loudly
- ☐ (D) He hugged the referee

4. Where was this World Cup match played?

- ☐ (A) In Scotland
- ☐ (B) In Haiti
- ☐ (C) In Boston
- ☐ (D) In Denmark

5. What does Ben Gannon-Doak do before games to stay calm?

- ☐ (A) He listens to pop music
- ☐ (B) He prays and reads the Bible
- ☐ (C) He calls his coach
- ☐ (D) He takes a nap

6. Which team is Scotland going to play next?

- ☐ (A) Haiti
- ☐ (B) China
- ☐ (C) Denmark
- ☐ (D) The Tartan Army

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

- 1. Excited Fan:** Scotland's supporters see Gannon-Doak as a new hero whose fire and determination have finally brought them hope after a very long, sad wait.
- 2. Cautious Optimist:** Some people worry that one good game does not mean Scotland will keep winning, especially since Gannon-Doak has a history of injuries that could stop him again.
- 3. Neutral Observer:** Sports experts note that sometimes a player's emotion and willpower, not just their skills, can lift an entire team and turn the tide of a competition.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):